Using students' lived experience in teaching

Do I treat students' lived experience as an asset?

WHAT IS IT?

Students' varied life experiences and ways of engaging are drawn on as an asset, not treated as a deficit

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

Teaching is never neutral. Choices about readings, cases, examples, guest speakers, classroom norms and professional pathways tell students whose lives and knowledge are considered normal, legitimate or peripheral. When students cannot recognise themselves or their communities in the discipline, participation can start to feel risky or pointless.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- "People like me do not seem to exist in this field."
- "We only appear when the course is discussing disadvantage or a problem."

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Invite different kinds of examples, applications and experiences into discussion.
- Avoid assuming there is one normal pathway or life situation behind every student response.
- Treat difference as useful insight into the field rather than a deviation from the norm.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

An engineering educator asks students to compare how a design would operate in different climates, communities and maintenance contexts.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

In this course, we aim to treat students' lived experience as a potential source of knowledge without requiring anyone to disclose or represent a whole group.

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Inclusive practice

Students as Partners